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Model Minority or Myth? Reexamining the Politics of S.I. Hayakawa

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ABSTRACT

This article problematizes the model minority myth as an analytic in discussions of Asian American conservatism by reassessing the personal and political development of S.I. Hayakawa, Acting President of San Francisco State College during the Third World Liberation Front strike of 1968–1969. Contemporary activists and Asian American studies scholars influenced by the strike’s legacy have seen Hayakawa as a staunch conservative and an advocate of the model minority myth. However, Hayakawa was primarily motivated by his lifelong identification with the liberal tradition and his work as an advocate for racial equality. His realignment as a neoconservative Republican reflected the shifting political landscape of the late 1960s and early 1970s rather than a transformation of his ideas. This article reexamines his ideas and activities to argue that, despite his legacy as a conservative, he in fact challenged and complicated the model minority myth’s depictions of Asian American passivity and assimilation. I argue that distinguishing the model minority myth and conservatism as two separate, though interrelated, concepts can open scholars to a fuller and more nuanced understanding of each within Asian American political and intellectual history.

KEYWORDS

Political history; S.I. Hayakawa; model minority myth; conservatism; liberalism

Introduction

“On strike, shut it down!” The chants of the Third World Liberation Front (TWLF) strike ripped through the sharp San Francisco air on the morning of December 2, 1968, as S.I. Hayakawa, the third president to serve San Francisco State College (SFSC) in that year alone, clambered on top of the protesters’ sound truck. The throng of strikers and supporters jeered as he stumbled, found his balance, and marched onto the roof of the truck. As the shouts rose again, he swung his arms at the crowd as if to egg them on, his fists balled, his chin thrust out defiantly. He wore a blue ribbon tied around his left arm and his trademark hat, a striped red and blue tam o’ shanter, whose jaunty angle clashed with his black suit and mood. With two sharp pulls he yanked the speaker’s wires out of the truck, and from below the crowd threw their expletives, shouts, and thick stacks of fliers at his face. “Off the truck!” they yelled. “Lackey pig!” He grinned as they began to boo.¹

This was the moment that made Samuel Ichiye Hayakawa – already known as a public intellectual and expert on communication and race relations – into a national political figure. His term as Acting President of SFSC would outlast the longest student strike in

U.S. history, which he suppressed by using the harsh methods his predecessors had been reluctant to employ. These included curtailing free speech and bringing in police tactical squads on campus, draconian measures that only further galvanized protesters against him. Yet in a year of global student unrest, people across the political spectrum lauded Hayakawa for his unyielding stance against the extremes of student radicalism. Others were divided, sympathetic to movements against racism and the Vietnam War, but unable to support either the protesters' or Hayakawa's militancy. Within a few short years, however, Hayakawa would leverage his celebrity to become elected to the U.S. Senate. The historic victory in 1976 made him the first nonwhite senator from California, the first Asian American senator from the mainland, and the nation's most prominent Asian American Republican.

Yet the field of Asian American studies remembers Hayakawa best as the buffoonish villain of the Third World Liberation Front strike at SFSC and the ultimate exemplar of the model minority myth. This historical memory has direct ties to the foundation of the field itself, as many of the activists and scholars who would establish Asian American studies after the strike formed their political identities in opposition to Hayakawa. Historian Daryl J. Maeda frames the SFSC conflict as "a pivotal moment in Asian American politics, for radicals advocated multiethnic and interracial solidarity, while Hayakawa argued that Asian Americans should strive to assimilate into the mainstream."² The "Asian American"—a new, explicitly political panethnic identity³—emerged in part through the rejection of Hayakawa as both an archetype of and a spokesman for the model minority stereotype. In its socioeconomic dimensions, the model minority myth claimed that Asian Americans were upwardly mobile "success stories" with low rates of crime and delinquency; in its cultural and political content, the myth portrayed Asian Americans as quiet, apolitical, and assimilationist. Functionally, the myth treated Asian Americans as a wedge group to divide multiracial coalitions, to mask violence and poverty within Asian American communities, to encourage Asian American silence rather than protest, and to ultimately "prove" that America is a colorblind meritocracy – all outcomes that benefited the conservative backlash to the social upheavals of the 1960s.⁴ Asian Americans who praised or accepted the model minority myth, like Hayakawa, have been condemned as conservatives, sellouts, or dupes who upheld white supremacy through their aspirations to whiteness or their underlying anti-blackness. As one Sansei TWLF member commented during the strike, for instance, "[Hayakawa] is a minority person but he's the highest order of an Uncle Tom."⁵

Yet equating the model minority myth with conservatism produces an oversimplification of both that flattens and dehistoricizes the diversity of Asian American politics. Even if Asian Americanist scholars and activists tend to disavow the model minority myth, it has been embraced widely and across the political spectrum. For instance, as entrepreneur Andrew Yang attracted progressive attention in the 2020 Democratic primary, he also used the stereotype to boost his profile by declaring that "the opposite of Donald Trump is an Asian man who likes math."⁶ Conversely, historical and contemporary communities of color have also adopted core conservative ideas – trust in business enterprise and the free market, a limited government in favor of local control, and the importance of personal responsibility – as tools for empowerment, regardless of their attitudes toward assimilation.⁷ By ascribing assimilationist motives to Asian American proponents of the

model minority myth, however, we leave little ground for analyzing the complexity of Asian American conservatism within the changing landscape of postwar U.S. politics.

As a result, we are left with critical gaps in our approaches to Asian American agency, intellectual history, and political history. Assimilationism and ignorance do not always characterize Asian American conservatives; they have, for instance, mobilized on the basis of ethnic identity, drawing on the history and language of anti-racism rather than assimilation. Others acting on pragmatism rather than principle have also made conservative or “quiet” choices, particularly when faced with racist or political violence. Yet little work has been done to examine how Asian American conservatives interpreted and applied concepts like assimilation, integration, and separatism as intellectual trends shifted over time. Similarly, we know little about Asian American relationships to the historical development of the modern conservative movement or the Republican Party at local, regional, national, and transnational levels.⁸ Although scholars have worked to undermine the model minority myth by highlighting Asian solidarity with other people of color, this has limited our attention to how Asian Americans have sought alternate paths beyond assimilation into whiteness or analogies to blackness.

This article revisits Hayakawa’s personal and political development to examine how the paradigmatic conservative of Asian American studies in fact challenged and complicated the model minority myth. As both an individual and a symbol, Hayakawa offers critical insights into the historiographical gaps outlined above. He was brash, outspoken, and reveled in controversy; indeed, his political success relied on rejecting the model minority myth’s passivity and apoliticism. Far from being repelled by his behavior, many Americans loved him precisely for punching back at radical protesters, making him into the first Asian American conservative celebrity and pundit. Hayakawa was not a newcomer to issues of race, having dedicated his career to understanding racial prejudice, and he also worked within and beyond academia to pursue racial and economic equality according to liberal democratic principles.⁹ His understanding of race relations changed over time, from first embracing assimilation and rejecting ethnic particularism to later accepting separatism as a step toward successful integration. He thus argued that Asian Americans had a unique role to play as mediators between whites and other minorities, providing guidance to the latter and reassurance to the former in order to promote cross-racial understanding and cooperation.¹⁰ In so doing, he joined a wider trend of Asian Americans who mobilized the narrative of success to theorize their distinctive role as allies in liberal multiracial politics.¹¹ He identified throughout his life with the liberal tradition, a centrist politics that sought to protect and promote the rights and freedoms of the individual. As such, he saw a clear role for government to remove economic and racial barriers that undermined the liberty of all Americans. However, changes in the political landscape of the 1970s – provoked by a backlash to militant protest and its perceived threats to the tradition of civil discourse – created his status and legacy as a conservative. Leftists condemned Hayakawa’s optimistic faith in racial liberalism as naïve and ignorant, while the Republican coalition welcomed him and other alienated liberals-turned-neoconservatives.¹²

Hayakawa’s story reveals that while the model minority myth and conservatism have significant overlaps, they should be understood as two distinct concepts, each with their own complex ideas and histories. By defying simple categorization as a liberal, conservative, or model minority, Hayakawa’s biography offers us critical insights into shifting conceptualizations of Asian American political roles and opportunities in a time of dramatic social change.

The making of a racial individualist

Well before the confrontation at SFSC catapulted Hayakawa into the national spotlight, he had established a modest reputation as an expert on communication and interracial relations, a public intellectual, a supporter of civil rights, and an occasional activist. His scholarly interest in communication was shaped by his experience as a monolingual minority, as he grew up in small cities across Canada with few other Japanese neighbors and struggled to build a relationship with his mother across their language divide.¹³ When he moved to the University of Wisconsin-Madison for his doctoral studies in English in 1929, he began to develop his lifelong identity as a liberal fighting for democratic principles in order to protect the rights of the individual. His ideas were shaped by his admiration for the corporation-busting progressive legacy of Wisconsin's Robert "Fighting Bob" La Follette, Sr., as well as his horror at the racist extremes of Nazi Germany.¹⁴

Like many other scholars and racial liberals of his generation, Hayakawa followed what historian Leah Gordon has described as the "racial individualist" orientation toward the problem of "race relations." This approach identified individual psychology as the key site to understand and combat racism, or more precisely, "racial prejudice."¹⁵ Alarmed by the Nazi state's use of mass media to spread its racial ideology, Hayakawa sought to understand how democracies could maintain core liberal values, like freedom of speech, while resisting media manipulation.¹⁶ General semantics, his field of expertise, examined how words unconsciously shaped beliefs and actions, including racism. Hayakawa first emphasized the difference between things and the words used to describe them. "Jew₁ is not Jew₂," he explained, because each person was unique from their coreligionists, and the same person could also change over time.¹⁷ He then criticized the construction of racial categories like "white" and "Negro" through arbitrary means like the "one-drop" rule.¹⁸ Because race, to him, was just a linguistic construct, it was simply a fiction that agitators used to mask their actual goals. "As every Negro knows, a 'race' issue is a perfect means of diverting attention from genuine economic, social and political problems. It is the prize red herring of all time."¹⁹ Therefore, Hayakawa argued, racial prejudice only existed because of individuals' "thoughtlessness" and "over-generalization." He explained that these problems derived from uncritical attitudes toward media stereotypes, and from the lack of interpersonal contact that could contradict such images.²⁰ In his mind, the solution to racial prejudice, therefore, was for people of all races to increase critical thinking, to encourage desegregation, and, finally, to end all languages of race.²¹ Hayakawa therefore counted himself as an assimilationist – but assimilation was a two-way street requiring the active participation of both minority and majority groups.

Hayakawa's work on communication made him a celebrated public intellectual and an authority on race relations. Shortly after he moved to Chicago in 1939, the Book-of-the-Month Club featured his general semantics textbook, *Language in Action*, as a tool for empowering everyday people to sustain democracy – even as plans for the mass incarceration of Japanese Americans on the West Coast made a mockery of the nation's democratic principles.²² A wide range of people, from businessmen to Playboy bunnies, read – or at least name-dropped – the book.²³ In November 1942, Hayakawa's audience grew further when he joined the Black-owned *Chicago Defender* as a weekly columnist.²⁴ Although he believed all people shared responsibility for ending racial prejudice, his attention to a Black audience led him to focus the majority of his critique on the racially oppressed themselves.

For instance, he condemned the hypocrisy of African Americans' and Japanese Americans' prejudice toward other groups, writing, "When will people understand that racial prejudice is of one piece, and that in perpetuating one kind of prejudice they are perpetuating all other kinds at the same time?"²⁵ He furthermore urged minorities to take greater responsibility for integration by critiquing what he called "self-imposed segregation" and "Jim Crow of the mind," which resulted when constant "defensiveness" against prejudice caused exhaustion and retreat into the comfort of one's own community. "One after another the barriers come down – not as fast as you'd like, perhaps – but they come down. Then, when they are down, where are the Negroes?"²⁶ If race was a linguistic construct whose masquerade distracted from real economic and political problems, then maintaining race-based associations and categories – especially as legalized racial discrimination seemed to be on the decline – only prolonged racism. Hayakawa critiqued Japanese American incarceration in the same vein, arguing that it was not just constitutionally questionable, but that it reinscribed race as an organizing principle and thereby delayed Japanese American assimilation.²⁷

Concern over race relations led Hayakawa to support the civil rights movement, but he primarily channeled his activism into the consumer cooperative movement. The cooperative movement sought to democratize the economy by centering "citizen consumers" who could control prices and production by pooling together their buying power.²⁸ Furthermore, Hayakawa argued, cooperatives undermined prejudice through economic common sense. "If you reject a couple of prospective [co-op] members because you don't like the color of their skins or the religion of their ancestors, you simply gyp yourself out of your savings."²⁹ As a result, he wrote, "Nobody thinks about 'race' at a co-op meeting. They cease to be 'white' or 'Negro' or 'yellow' or 'brown,' and become just simply 'co-operators.' And if that isn't what we're shooting for, I don't know what is."³⁰ Many African American proponents of the movement, including W.E.B. DuBois and Ella Baker, differed from Hayakawa by emphasizing the potential of cooperatives to build Black economic power rather than to diminish racial thinking.³¹ Nonetheless, organizers like Halena Wilson of the Ladies Auxiliary to the Brotherhood of Sleeping Car Porters welcomed Hayakawa as an authority on the benefits of cooperatives on race relations.³² Hayakawa and his wife, Margedant Peters, became active leaders in cooperative associations, from their local Hyde Park Cooperative Society on the South Side of Chicago to the regional Central States Cooperatives; they also made a point of supporting Black-owned cooperatives like the People's Consumer Cooperative and the South Shore Cooperative.³³ Beyond the cooperative movement, Hayakawa also donated to civil rights groups like the Anti-Discrimination Committee of the JACL, the NAACP, the Urban League of Chicago, and the ACLU.³⁴

When Hayakawa moved to northern California in 1955 to begin teaching at SFSC, he continued to advocate for liberal causes on and off campus. In the late 1950s, he served on the Marin County Committee on Racial Discrimination and joined local efforts to test housing rights.³⁵ In January 1963, he spearheaded Friends of Free Radio, organizing public rallies in Berkeley to support three FM radio stations under investigation for Communist infiltration.³⁶ Later that year he urged SFSC students to "reviv[e] the militant spirit which characterized pre-Civil War Abolitionists," and called for schools, businesses, and unions to take proactive measures toward desegregation and affirmative action. "Successful communication with our Negro fellow citizens must begin," he explained, "as all communications must begin, with a recognition that words are not enough, that words must be the prelude to

actions, and that actions must be earnestly considered and honestly proposed in the light of the full historical context and the present realities.”³⁷ In early 1964, he spoke at a conference at Pomona College on Civil Equality, headlining the program alongside civil rights movement leaders James Farmer of CORE and James Forman of SNCC.³⁸ Hayakawa was eager not only to join the conversation on racial liberalism and economic democracy, but also to take action to realize social change.

Defending the liberal tradition

As the 1960s wore on, however, a new turn in student militancy began to shift the political ground under Hayakawa’s feet. Hayakawa had long sought to promote liberal democratic values, but as activists began to pursue increasingly combative and even violent tactics to achieve their goals, he condemned them as fundamentally illiberal. Students, meanwhile, began to interpret racism as a power structure rather than prejudice, and criticized racial individualism as outdated, insufficient, and reactionary. For Asian American Movement (AAM) activists in particular, Hayakawa appeared to be not just ignorant or naïve, but a puppet who allowed his ethnicity to be manipulated as a buffer for white supremacy. Though radical protest caused Hayakawa to soften his stance on assimilation, he began to find the warmest welcome for his defense of racial liberalism among neoconservatives in the Republican Party.

Since witnessing the radical tactics of the 1964 Free Speech Movement at UC Berkeley, Hayakawa had begun to suspect that the New Left did not seek what he considered to be real social progress. Instead, he feared that it was driven by an antidemocratic ideological extremism. Hayakawa argued that the Berkeley students’ strategies – including pickets, mass demonstrations, and the occupation of campus buildings – did not encourage free speech but rather “[made] rational discussion impossible.” Furthermore, their resistance to disciplinary action for violating campus rules suggested to Hayakawa that they refused to accept the consequences of civil disobedience, and were instead seeking “credit for martyrdom without martyrdom.”³⁹ In a reflection on the 1965 Watts uprising, he worried that the New Left would only undermine the civil rights movement. African Americans faced not only a conservative “white backlash” to civil rights demonstrations, he wrote, but “even more threatening [...] are certain elements in the New Left who present themselves as friends of the Negro.” To Hayakawa, they were merely using Black protest to discredit the government, and as ideological purists they would never join the coalitions and “practical negotiation” that were fundamental to the workings of American politics. “The only hope for minorities,” Hayakawa concluded, “[...] lies in the broad center of both major parties [...] in those who in the pragmatic, commonsense tradition of American life, will continue to hammer out the agreements and accommodations that we all must make to live together in peace and progress.”⁴⁰

Thus, from Hayakawa’s perspective, the TWLF strike at SFSC did not establish the country’s first School of Ethnic Studies, but rather delayed its founding and undermined the legitimate needs of its would-be beneficiaries.⁴¹ When the Black Student Union (BSU) and the TWLF issued their “nonnegotiable” demands in November 1968, Hayakawa saw their behavior as demonstrating an antidemocratic refusal to engage in conversation and compromise. When protesters disrupted classes and offices, overturned desks and destroyed equipment, set fires, and clashed with police, Hayakawa believed they were using demonstrations “to threaten or coerce others into agreement or silence,” and to “create confusion

so that the ‘power structure’ [would] be goaded into acts of tyranny (‘police brutality’).⁴² When students formed the Movement Against Political Suspension to protest any disciplinary actions – a group of “authority rebels” that Hayakawa saw “at the center of every campus disturbance for years” – it appeared to Hayakawa that they had abdicated all responsibility for their behavior.⁴³ Hayakawa acknowledged that students had legitimate grievances, but he believed they were poorly served by the strike’s extremist leadership.⁴⁴

Hayakawa sprang into action to advance the interests of moderate students, staff, and faculty, which he termed the “silent center.”⁴⁵ His first goal was to bring “rationality and order” to campus before negotiations could proceed.⁴⁶ He reminded his colleagues that they had “a standing obligation to our 17,500 or more students white, black, yellow, and brown, who are not on strike.”⁴⁷ These students, many of whom were commuters, returning, or part-time students, “have neither the money or the time to lose a semester’s worth of credit.”⁴⁸ Second, he tried to find a compromise between the strikers’ demands and SFSC’s capacities, arguing that the BSU’s demand to waive admissions requirements for all Black applicants, while impractical, rightly called attention to the city’s underserved communities. He urged the school to instead expand its citywide outreach to new immigrant communities, working adults, and part-time students.⁴⁹

Hayakawa may have hoped to use his experiences in communication and race relations to defuse tensions when he became Acting President in late November 1968, but he undercut his conciliatory gestures with condescending lectures based on racial individualism. In his first press conference on November 30, Hayakawa invited the BSU and TWLF to discuss Ethnic Studies curricula, noting that he had “been inundated [with] offers of financial support” for such programs. “I want to be counted as an ally,” he declared. Yet he also criticized the students for fabricating “the impression [of] an oppressive and racist society determined to resist” them. Comparing racial progress in the U.S. to apartheid in South Africa, he chided that “such struggle is largely unnecessary – almost comically inappropriate in light of the realities. The fact is that America is not all a racist society in principle and only partially a racist society in fact.” The BSU and TWLF only needed to show that they would “wisely” use public resources. After all, Hayakawa noted, the civil rights movement’s victories showed that “society is ready and willing to grant so much.”⁵⁰ He invited the students to negotiate, but refused to consider their analysis of structural racism.

More dissonance between Hayakawa’s words and actions followed, and his performative theatrics and controversial, flippant statements came to define his presidency. The images of Hayakawa pulling out the wires on the sound truck on December 2 turned him, “in his own words, [into] a ‘folk hero’,” iconic for his colorful tam o’shanter and his gleeful, get-tough statements. He held almost daily press conferences for the first week, to the point that one of his frustrated advisers later recalled, “I kept trying to interest him in the issues at the college, but he was only interested in public relations.” When nine students were injured and 31 arrested on December 3 in an aggressive police crackdown that came to be known as “Bloody Tuesday,” Hayakawa said, “This was the most exciting day of my life since my tenth birthday, when I rode a roller coaster for the first time.”⁵¹ The following day, he met with 80 Black community leaders, including State Assemblyman Willie Brown and Berkeley City Councilman Ron Dellums, who asked him to call the police off campus and to suspend classes. He was dismissive and presumptuous, saying, “I, as a minority, see my role as interpreting your concern to the white community,” and telling one woman, “Now look,

baby, you people have got to understand. ... ” When the group burst out in anger, Hayakawa walked out of the meeting.⁵² His behavior and policies only polarized the campus more, further eroding space for the moderate center for which he claimed to advocate.

Among the TWLF strikers were a new generation of Asian American activists, who were not only disgusted by Hayakawa’s conduct but particularly offended by his role as a racial middleman. The first published discussion of Asian Americans as a “middleman minority” appeared in *Gidra*, a Los Angeles-based newspaper that became the AAM’s most widely circulated publication. Writer Alan Nishio used Hayakawa as his primary example to demonstrate how the white elite manipulated Asians as a “buffer” against Black and Brown minorities.⁵³ Instead, the AAM sought to define Asians in solidarity with oppressed and colonized Third World peoples at home and abroad – a position that rejected both assimilation and the model minority stereotype.⁵⁴ *Gidra* explained: “Yellow Power is a call for Asian Americans to end the silence that has condemned us to suffer in this racist society [...]. It is a rejection of the passive Oriental stereotype and symbolizes the birth of a new Asian – one who will recognize and deal with injustices.” A drawing of a bold samurai brandishing his sword at the reader accompanied the article, calling readers to a new culture of power, pride, and protest (Figure 1).⁵⁵ Yellow Power would oppose the manipulation of Asian Americans as a passive “middleman minority” that was “used as a buffer by the Establishment in the confrontation between racial groups”—just as, Nishio explained, “yellow Uncle Toms like Hayakawa are placed in positions as figureheads to be used by Reagan and others [...]”.⁵⁶ Yet the AAM struggled to attract mainstream attention. Three of the six groups in the TWLF were Asian American, but media reports and student publications tended to neglect their participation and instead foregrounded Black and white students, with Mexican American students as supporting characters.⁵⁷ In 1969, SFSC’s own journalism school printed a retrospective in which interviews with the strike leaders only featured the BSU, the Mexican-American Student Alliance, and Students for a Democratic Society (SDS).⁵⁸

The most prominent Asian American in the strike, therefore, was Hayakawa – who was quickly becoming a national political celebrity and a symbol of irreverent, independent defiance. Liberals and conservatives across the country thanked him for standing up to student protesters.⁵⁹ He was achieving what other campus administrators had failed to do – and in style. A *Los Angeles Times* feature contrasted protesters’ theatrics with Hayakawa’s “personal flamboyance.” It described his unorthodox suggestions for bringing peace to campus, like inviting gospel singer Mahalia Jackson to perform on campus, or adorning policemen with flowers to signal their intent as peacekeepers.⁶⁰ Political cartoonists dressed Hayakawa up as a martial artist who swiftly dispatched unruly youth from his office (Figure 2).⁶¹ The California state legislature commended Hayakawa and declared its full support for the “modern-day Samurai-in-tam-o’shanter,”⁶² and he lived up to his reputation as a fighter. On March 3 1969, he visited the University of Colorado Boulder, where student demonstrators delayed the start of his talk for an hour, reportedly hurling obscenities, cigarettes, and chairs at the stage.⁶³ Undeterred, Hayakawa told the students, “You might as well start your rally outside because I can out wait this longer than you can.” He launched into his speech, bringing the audience back to 1938 and the tactics of disruption and manipulation that accompanied the rise of Nazism – and which, he argued, students had now adopted. As the protesters’ shouts interrupted him, Hayakawa raised his voice too. “Shut up, you can’t scare me, drop dead!” he yelled. “I can outlast any of you. Are you



Figure 1. Larry Kubota, "Necessary but not sufficient: Yellow Power!" *Gidra* 1, no. 1 (April 1969).



Figure 2. Caption reads, "It's a Sad State of Affairs When a Militant Minority Can Take Over a Campus!" Handwritten comment to S.I. Hayakawa reads, "I say so! Good for you – I agree. Keep up the good work if you can and keep America free." *Milwaukee Journal*, n.d., Folder 8, Box 626, SIH.

prepared to stay here until 11? So am I." To the audience, he explained, "Right here, you are seeing a demonstration of the denial of the freedom of speech and the ideal of Nazism."⁶⁴ The next day, the *Denver Post* enthusiastically praised Hayakawa's composure with headlines like "CU Antics 'Amuse' Hayakawa" and "Hayakawa Hits 'New Hitlerism'."⁶⁵

Ironically, Hayakawa's theatrics laughed in the face of the same "passive Oriental stereotype" that *Gidra* and the AAM also rejected. But far from condemning Hayakawa for breaking that stereotype, the American public adored the "tough little samurai with the jaunty tam-o-shanter."⁶⁶ Was this a case in which people with a superficial understanding of the SFSC conflict simply approved of anyone who would shut down student militancy? Many of Hayakawa's supporters may have fallen into this category, which suggests that Americans may have approved of a "militant minority" only when they stood in defense of law and order.⁶⁷ However, other supporters included those who had followed his work on

race relations and the cooperative movement for decades, and believed he was sincerely using his position to further racial equality. The *Chicago Defender*, for instance, lauded him as a liberal who “did a much better job of presenting the students’ case than the students themselves had been able to do.”⁶⁸

AAM writers pushed back by trying to delegitimize Hayakawa’s public authority as a spokesman for Asian Americans. They labeled him both as the ultimate representative of the model minority narrative that had silenced their communities, yet also as a total stranger to those same communities. A defining attribute of the “passive Oriental,” *Gidra* argued, was an optimistic view of racial progress. Hayakawa seemed to possess this exact naïveté, infamously praising Japanese American cooperation with wartime incarceration for shaming Americans so that “it’ll never happen to the Japanese American again,” a statement that smacked of obsequiousness. Yet *Gidra* also questioned Hayakawa’s Asian American identity by suggesting he had no understanding of Asian American life. For one, he had no grounds to speak about incarceration, as a Japanese Canadian who escaped that fate by virtue of living in the Midwest. Furthermore, he was ignorant of the actual conditions of Asian American communities, naively praising San Francisco’s “fine Chinatown” without realizing the dire poverty of its residents.⁶⁹ The slurs that *Gidra* writers hurled at Hayakawa — “banana,” “yellow Uncle Tom” — mocked him as Asian superficially, but white inside.⁷⁰ The first textbook for Asian American studies, *Roots: An Asian American Reader* (1971), concurred. Like *Gidra*, the editors of *Roots* sought to raise Asian American political consciousness by debunking the “success myth,” a “white-majority perspective on Asian Americans which many Americans, Asians included, support without question.” But even if many Asian Americans themselves supported the myth — and, in fact, supported Hayakawa — the editors argued that Hayakawa, the myth’s “most publicized spokesman,” still did not represent Asian Americans. Indeed, he was not even part of the Asian American community. “White America has appointed S.I. Hayakawa as its spokesman for Asians in America. Yet [...] Hayakawa makes clear his past and continuing disassociation with other Asian Americans and their community experience.”⁷¹ Hayakawa was not of the Asian American community, *Roots* suggested, but a pawn of white supremacy.

Hayakawa was indeed proud to declare himself independent of the Japanese American community — including independence from the Japanese cultural values supposedly responsible for the model minority myth. Indeed, he argued, it was this independence that had made his role as a mediator in the SFSC strike possible. In his interview with the *Roots* editors, Hayakawa summarized sociologist Harry Kitano’s analysis of the “enryo syndrome” as the opposite of the Jewish word “chutzpah”: “non-presumptuousness.”⁷² To be non-presumptuous, he explained, was to “acknowledge the line of authority,” rather than “barging in and making demands and making noise about it.” This attitude was simply pragmatic and “tactful” for minorities. But, Hayakawa declared, “I don’t have this non-presumptuousness.” He had never been “a member of the Japanese-Canadian community” since his was the only Japanese family in each town growing up. As the eldest son, furthermore, he was “spoiled” and “indulged.” His mother had also imparted a sense of self-importance onto Hayakawa by separating him from his childhood playmates, telling him, “We are the representatives of another class of people.”⁷³ Thus, Hayakawa argued, he had never doubted his ability to “do something about” the SFSC confrontations.⁷⁴ In essence, Hayakawa suggested that his distance from other Asians had also allowed him to defy the model minority stereotype. He was not particularly Asian, and therefore, he was not

beholden to Asian cultural values either. He could stand apart from not just whites and Blacks, but also from Asian Americans. To Hayakawa, it was this difference – the state of being an outsider to all ethnic and racial groups, yet possessing a deep empathy and critical understanding of discrimination due to his personal experiences and his scholarly expertise – that made him into a perfect neutral mediator in interracial disputes.

Although Hayakawa took a stubborn pride in his independence from Japanese culture, the years of protest and upheaval had caused him to revise his previously dismissive attitude toward the value of ethnic identity. Before the mid-1960s, Hayakawa had argued that assimilation required both minorities and majorities to change their attitudes, and therefore that minorities had the particular duty of rejecting ethnic particularism and “self-imposed segregation.” But the events of 1965 appeared to change his mind. Mere days after the Watts uprising, Hayakawa began to argue for limited segregation as a means of developing Black economic strength and psychological pride. “I’m not a segregationist,” he said at a lecture at Monterey Peninsula College, “but some segregation might be helpful for the length of time needed. It could be a source of self-strengthening and gathering of morale, so that the Negro can get the strength to go into the larger community.”⁷⁵

Thus, while AAM activists called on Asian Americans to reject their manipulation as a racial middleman by the white elite, Hayakawa instead argued that because Asian Americans were socioeconomic intermediaries, they had not just an active role in creating a more equal society, but a unique duty to do so. Speaking to a crowd of predominantly middle- and upper-class Japanese Americans in February 1969, Hayakawa argued that Asian Americans had a special role in demonstrating the “complementary” relationship of separatism and integration.⁷⁶ Chinatowns, for instance, provided a space for Chinese Americans to restore their “courage” before rejoining white society; their integrationist efforts, meanwhile, helped whites respect Chinatown instead of viewing it with suspicion. Likewise, Japanese Americans had retained their families and communities intact, providing the strength for individuals “to go out into the world of *hakujin* (whites).” Drawing on the notion that cultural strength could overcome racism, Hayakawa concluded that Asians had a “great obligation” to “act as intermediaries between the white and the black,” providing an example to the latter while easing the fears of the former.⁷⁷ Hayakawa’s statement departed significantly from his previous insistence on assimilation and his opposition to ethnic-specific organizations. He still located the site of societal change in the behavior and psychology of the individual, but instead of rejecting ethnic particularism, he now gave a distinct role to ethnic pride. He urged Asian Americans to draw on their identities and their struggles in order to support African Americans. Activists ignored the uniqueness of the Asian American position to their deficit, he declared to the *Roots* editors. “My criticism of Sansei and the radical Orientals [...] is that ... they play Black Panther [...] they have not developed their own critical style which says ‘We are not white, we are not black’.”⁷⁸ But Hayakawa’s framework also blithely placed Asians in a position of authority over Blacks – a stance that likely influenced his condescending behavior during strike negotiations.

Hayakawa’s shifting ideas on assimilation as well as his controversial status at SFSC reflected not only struggles over Asian American identity, but also the changing political landscape. The Democratic coalition of organized labor, urban white ethnics, and African Americans that had dominated U.S. politics since the New Deal was rapidly disintegrating. Many white Southerners and blue-collar white Northerners abandoned the Democrats in an

outright backlash against Black, feminist, gay, and antiwar movements, while middle-class suburbanites throughout the country framed their conservatism as a colorblind defense of individual rights. But even many liberals and moderates were alienated by radical protests and believed that the Democratic Party had abandoned the liberal tradition, leaving it to be inherited by the Republican Party.⁷⁹ Hayakawa joined these voters in leaving the Democratic Party. He had been involved in deliberations on the party's future, discussing campus unrest at the Democratic State Central Committee's conference on Party Reform and Reorganization in April 1969. Many of his friends had even advised him to run for Senate as a Democrat.⁸⁰ Yet the day after he resigned as SFSC President in October 1973, he switched his registration to the Republican Party, explaining that Democrats had abandoned true liberalism. "I belong with those intellectuals (if I must have a classification) who write for and/or read journals as 'The Public Interest' and 'Commentary' – for example, Nathan Glazer, Daniel Bell, Daniel P. Moynihan, Thomas Sowell and Sidney Hook, all of whom started out as 'liberals' but whom the liberals abandoned by THEIR shift of opinion to an all-embracing statism."⁸¹ When Hayakawa won in 1976, he became the first Asian American Senator from the U.S. mainland. Now, he not only represented Asian American success – he represented the state of California, and the rightward drift of the nation's politics.

Conclusion

In September 1978, a symposium at the meeting of the American Political Science Association in New York reflected on recent Asian American political participation. Both Japanese and Chinese Americans continued to have little influence at the time, Michael Roskin and Moon H. Jo of Lycoming College noted, as they were hampered by internal conflicts over identity. "Ironically," they concluded, "the only political success that Asian-American radicals have contributed to is the rise to prominence of S.I. Hayakawa [...] and his subsequent election to the Senate as a conservative."⁸²

Hayakawa was a divisive figure, particularly among Asian Americans – yet there was no mistaking that he did not fit into the image of the passive, apolitical model minority that activists tried to critique. While his style was perhaps the most obvious contradiction to the model minority myth, the substance of his political thought and activities poses a deeper challenge to our understanding of the myth's relationship to Asian American conservatism. Re-examining Hayakawa within his own context reveals that he was not a passive assimilationist, but someone who actively sought to combat inequality throughout his life. He mobilized the model minority myth not to promote complacency with the status quo, but to advocate for a specific Asian American role in social change. Despite shifts in his thinking over time, his fundamental adherence to the outdated analysis of racial individualism led him to ally with neoconservative Republicans in order to defend the traditional liberal order against what he perceived as threats of antidemocratic extremism.

This article argues that while Asian American studies has been shaped by a leftist politics deeply informed by the TWLF strikes, a full understanding of Asian American politics remains incomplete without attention to conservatives and Republicans within our communities. Approaching the model minority myth and conservatism as separate, though interrelated, concepts can help refine our analysis of each within Asian American history. Hayakawa's approach to Asian Americans as "intermediaries," for instance, demonstrates

that the model minority myth's multiple aspects could be deployed to support or protest diverse political positions and policies. Such research can also offer new insights into Asian American intersections with broader intellectual and political trends. For instance, some civil rights strategists like Bayard Rustin came to criticize militant protest for undermining the potential for coalition-building and negotiation within the political system.⁸³ It also remains unclear how Hayakawa compares to other conservatives of color. As a senator, he was a more consistent party vote than even Barry Goldwater, Robert Dole, or Strom Thurmond, but he voted against conservative grassroots demands on divisive issues like the return of the Panama Canal.⁸⁴ Furthermore, just as historians have called for a dialectical approach to studying conservatism and liberalism, so too can Asian Americanists examine the productive tensions that Hayakawa often represented.⁸⁵ His public platform allowed him to voice controversial opinions, but that same publicity often helped galvanize oppositional grassroots movements. For instance, Hayakawa's praise of Japanese American incarceration helped to unify the coalition that ultimately won redress; similarly, Hayakawa lent his public profile to the "English Only" movement of the 1980s, but it politicized new Asian American immigrant communities in cities like Monterey Park.⁸⁶

As a person and as a symbol, Hayakawa was key to the founding of Asian American studies, and he remains critical to our research in Asian American political and intellectual history. The model minority myth has long obscured the socioeconomic diversity of Asian American communities, but the effort to undermine the myth – arguably one of the core political projects of Asian American studies – has also obscured our political diversity. Studying Hayakawa as a full individual within his own historical context, rather than merely as a middleman minority and symbolic figurehead, challenges us to grapple with this complexity.

Notes

1. "Confrontations & Hayakawa on the Sound Truck," *KQED News*, December 2, 1968, San Francisco Bay Area Television Archive, <https://diva.sfsu.edu/collections/sfbatv/bundles/187201>; "San Francisco State – Hayakawa's First Day," *KQED News*, December 2, 1968, San Francisco Bay Area Television Archive, <https://diva.sfsu.edu/collections/sfbatv/bundles/189570>; Don W. Scoble, "Statement of Events Regarding Sound Truck Incident," December 27, 1968, Folder 6, Box 627, S.I. Hayakawa Papers (SIH), Hoover Institution Archives (HIA); and Samuel Ichiye (S.I.) Hayakawa, untitled draft of chapters 1–4, July 20, 1972, Folder 3, Box 626, SIH, 2. On the TWLF strike, see Martha Biondi, *The Black Revolution on Campus* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2012); Fabio Rojas, *From Black Power to Black Studies: How a Radical Social Movement Became an Academic Discipline* (Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press, 2007); and Noliwe Rooks, *White Money/Black Power: The Surprising History of African American Studies* (Boston: Beacon Press, 2006). On the role of Asian Americans in the strike, and its impact on the Asian American Movement, see Karen Umemoto, "On Strike! San Francisco State College Strike, 1968–1969: The Role of Asian American Students," *Amerasia Journal* 15, no. 1 (1989): 3–41; William Wei, *The Asian American Movement* (Philadelphia: Temple University Press, 1993); Daryl J. Maeda, *Chains of Babylon: The Rise of Asian America* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2009); Angela Ryan, "Counter College: Third World Students Reimagine Public Higher Education," *History of Education Quarterly* 55, no. 4 (November 2015): 413–40; and Karen L. Ishizuka, *Serve the People: Making Asian America in the Long Sixties* (New York: Verso, 2016). For an analysis of Hayakawa's role in the power dynamics between students and administration

- before, during, and after the strike, see Fabio Rojas, “Power Through Institutional Work: Acquiring Academic Authority in the 1968 Third World Strike,” *Academy of Management Journal* 53, no. 6 (December 2010): 1263–80.
2. Maeda, *Chains of Babylon*, 41. Hayakawa is also remembered for his opposition to another foundational moment of Asian American political activism, the campaign for Japanese American redress and reparations. Numerous scholars mention his opposition, including Maeda. For more details, see John Tateishi, *Redress: The Inside Story of the Successful Campaign for Japanese American Reparations* (Berkeley: Heyday, 2020); Robert Sadamu Shimabukuro, *Born in Seattle: The Campaign for Japanese American Redress* (Seattle: University of Washington Press, 2001); Alice Yang Murray, *Historical Memories of the Japanese American Internment and the Struggle for Redress* (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2008); Mitchell T. Maki, Harry H.L. Kitano, and S. Megan Berthold, *Achieving the Impossible Dream: How Japanese Americans Obtained Redress* (Urbana: University of Illinois Press, 1999); Bill Hosokawa, *JACL in Quest of Justice: The History of the Japanese American Citizens League* (New York: William and Morrow, 1982); and Vivian Yan-Gonzalez, “A Spectrum Apart: Chinese And Japanese American Republicans And Conservatives, 1920–1990” (Ph.D. diss., Stanford University, 2022).
 3. Yén Lê Espiritu, *Asian American Panethnicity: Bridging Institutions and Identities* (Philadelphia: Temple University Press, 1992).
 4. On the construction and deployments of the model minority myth in the postwar US, see Scott Kurashige, *The Shifting Grounds of Race: Black and Japanese Americans in the Making of Multiethnic Los Angeles* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2008); Cindy I-Fen Cheng, *Citizens of Asian America: Democracy and Race During the Cold War* (New York: New York University Press, 2013); Ellen D. Wu, *The Color of Success: Asian Americans and the Origins of the Model Minority* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2013); and Madeline Y. Hsu, *The Good Immigrants: How the Yellow Peril Became the Model Minority* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2015).
 5. “S.I. Hayakawa heads strife-torn San Francisco State College,” *Pacific Citizen*, December 6, 1968.
 6. John Bowden, “Yang: I’m the opposite of Trump, an ‘Asian man who likes math’,” *The Hill*, July 31, 2019, <https://thehill.com/homenews/campaign/455639-yang-im-the-opposite-of-trump-an-asian-man-who-likes-math/>.
 7. On intersections of conservatism with Black nationalism, see Peter Eisenstadt, ed., *Black Conservatism: Essays in Intellectual and Political History* (1998). The overlap in conservative and leftist values can be seen even in Glenn Omatsu’s critique of Asian American neoconservatives, in which he urged activists to challenge the ability of conservatives to “appropriate Asian culture”: “Do sacrifice, toil, and family values comprise a conservative moral vision only – or do these qualities also constitute the core of radical and revolutionary thinking?” Glenn Omatsu, “The Four Prisons and the Movements of Liberation: Asian American Activism from the 1960s to the 1990s,” in *The State of Asian America: Activism and Resistance in the 1990s*, ed. Karin Aguilar-San Juan (Boston: South End Press, 1994), 62–63.
 8. On assimilation as a pragmatic or defensive politics, see John Modell, *The Economics and Politics of Racial Accommodation: The Japanese of Los Angeles, 1900–1942* (Urbana, IL: University of Illinois Press 1977); Jere Takahashi, *Nisei/Sansei: Shifting Japanese American Identities and Politics* (Philadelphia: Temple University Press, 1997); and Jonathan Okamura, “Writing the Filipino Diaspora,” *Social Process in Hawai’i* 37 (1996). On Japanese American postwar interpretations of assimilation, see Greg Robinson, *After Camp: Portraits in Midcentury Japanese American Life and Politics* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2012), 67–102. On pragmatic strategies within multiracial coalitions, see Mark Brilliant, *The Color of America Has Changed: How Racial Diversity Shaped Civil Rights Reform in California, 1941–1978* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2010). On the role of China and the China Lobby in the modern conservative movement, see Joyce Mao, *Asia First: China and the Making of Modern Conservatism* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press 2015). On Asian Americans and race relations theory, see Henry Yu, *Thinking Orientals: Migration, Contact, and Exoticism in Modern America* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2001). New research is emerging on transpacific evangelicalism and on Asians and Asian Americans in the Christian Right; see Helen Jin Kim, *Race for Revival: How Cold War*

South Korea Shaped the American Evangelical Empire (New York: Oxford University Press, 2022) and Jane Hong, *Model Christians, Model Minorities: Asian Americans, Race, and Politics in the Transformation of U.S. Evangelicalism* (forthcoming).

9. Robinson, *After Camp*; and Yusuke Torii, "S. I. Hayakawa and the African American Community in Chicago, 1939–1955," *Setsudai Jinmonkagaku* 21 (January 2014): 25–49.
10. Here I challenge arguments that Hayakawa was "remarkably consistent commitment to assimilation, integration, and a shared public sphere as the solutions to the problem of racism" by emphasizing changes in his interpretation of assimilation and integration over time. Maeda, *Chains of Babylon*, 42; and Torii, "S. I. Hayakawa and the African American Community in Chicago."
11. Wu, *The Color of Success*; and Yan-Gonzalez, "A Spectrum Apart."
12. While historians have identified deeper roots of the "long conservative movement" dating back to the 1940s, Hayakawa's relationship to conservatism is best represented by scholarship on the "backlash" to social movements of the late 1960s and on neoconservatism. It should be noted that the neoconservatives that Omatsu critiques were of a younger generation than Hayakawa. On neoconservatism, see Justin Vaïsse, *Neoconservatism: The Biography of a Movement* (Cambridge, MA: Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 2011); and Angela D. Dillard, *Guess Who's Coming to Dinner Now? Multicultural Conservatism in America* (New York: New York University Press, 2001). On Hayakawa, see Christopher Plante, "Samuel Ichiyé Hayakawa: L'évolution De La Pensée D'un Intellectuel Libéral Devenu Néoconservateur: 1940–1970" (MA thesis, Université du Québec à Montréal, 2013); Yusuke Torii, "S. I. Hayakawa and the Civil Rights Era," in *Transpacific Correspondence: Dispatches from Japan's Black Studies*, eds. Yuichiro Onishi and Fumiko Sakashita (Cham, Switzerland: Palgrave Macmillan, 2019), 167–82; and Zevi Gutfreund, "Language, Citizenship, and the 'Model Minority Myth': The Political Conservatism of Nisei Language Scholars in California," *Southern California Quarterly* 101, no. 2 (May 2019): 205–41.
13. Digby Diehl, "Q&A: S.I. Hayakawa," *Los Angeles Times WEST Magazine*, February 6, 1972; and S.I. Hayakawa and Margedant Peters Hayakawa, "From Semantics to the U.S. Senate, Etc., Etc.," interview by Julie Gordon Shearer, 1989, Regional Oral History Office, Bancroft Library, 19.
14. S.I. Hayakawa, untitled essay about Japan, 1937, Unpublished Papers, Box 411, SIH.
15. Leah N. Gordon, *From Power to Prejudice: The Rise of Racial Individualism in Midcentury America* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2015).
16. Hayakawa's work joined a broad group of intellectuals and artists seeking democratic alternatives to authoritarian mass media. See Fred Turner, *The Democratic Surround: Multimedia and American Liberalism from World War II to the Psychedelic Sixties* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2013). My thanks to Jennifer Burns for highlighting this source.
17. S.I. Hayakawa, *Language in Action: A Guide to Accurate Thinking, Reading and Writing* (New York: Harcourt, Brace and Co., 1941), 195.
18. Ibid, 154.
19. S.I. Hayakawa, "Anatomy of racism," *Chicago Defender*, December 23, 1944.
20. S.I. Hayakawa, "To 'Charley Cherokee,'" May 22, 1943; "All blood-thirsty monsters," March 10, 1945; "Semantics of generalization," January 26, 1946; and all in *Chicago Defender*..
21. S.I. Hayakawa, "The wrong time for thought?" *Chicago Defender*, July 3, 1943.
22. Christopher Morley, "Language in Action, by S.I. Hayakawa," November Book-of-the-Month Club News, December 1941.
23. "Playboy Playmate of the Month Has Campus Men Excited," *The Daily Californian*, September 20, 1963. The book was renamed *Language in Thought and Action* beginning with the second edition in 1949. The fifth edition was printed in 1990.
24. Although Hayakawa was invited to be a columnist by the *Defender* editor, Dr. Metz Lochard, Hayakawa recalled, "Later on, I discovered that nobody else on the Defender staff had any particular enthusiasm for me. [...] I never got to know them particularly well. Dr. Lochard took all my time on the occasion when I visited the *Chicago Defender* office." He was "on friendly terms" with fellow columnist Langston Hughes but "didn't see him very often." S. Hayakawa and M. Hayakawa, 89, 139–141.

25. S.I. Hayakawa, "Sauce for the Goose," February 13, 1943; "Racism in All Directions," August 12, 1944; all in *Chicago Defender*.
26. Hayakawa did not specify particular changes, but he was likely considering events such as the response to A. Philip Randolph's threatened march on Washington, notably President Roosevelt's executive order integrating wartime industries and the creation of the Federal Employment Practices Committee. S.I. Hayakawa, "Defensiveness," January 22, 1944; "More Nerve Needed," December 14, 1946; "Absence of Negroes," March 30, 1946; "Letter to Three Students," June 1, 1946; "Where Are the Negroes?" October 12, 1946; and all in *Chicago Defender*.
27. S.I. Hayakawa, "Japanese-Americans in wartime," October 28, 1944; "Race-Consciousness in Relocation Camps," November 11, 1944; "Most Sweeping and Complete Deprivations," February 10, 1945; and all in *Chicago Defender*. Hayakawa reprinted excerpts of Justice Frank Murphy's dissenting opinion in *Korematsu v. United States* (1944) in one of his columns without comment. See also Robinson, 96–97.
28. Rosanne Currarino, *The Labor Question in America: Economic Democracy in the Gilded Age* (Urbana: University of Illinois Press, 2011); Jessica Gordon Nembhard, *Collective Courage: A History of African American Cooperative Economic Thought and Practice* (State College: Pennsylvania State University Press, 2014); and Joshua L. Carreiro, "Consumers' Cooperation in the Early Twentieth Century: An Analysis of Race, Class and Consumption" (Ph.D. diss., University of Massachusetts, Amherst, 2015).
29. The term "gyp" is now considered a racial slur. S.I. Hayakawa, "Theory and Practice," *Chicago Defender*, February 20, 1943.
30. S.I. Hayakawa, "My One-Track Mind," *Chicago Defender*, May 29, 1943.
31. Nembhard, *Collective Courage*. See also Irvin J. Hunt, *Dreaming the Present: Time, Aesthetics, and the Black Cooperative Movement* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 2022).
32. Halena Wilson, letter to David Kellum, April 19, 1943, 118–6, Brotherhood of Sleeping Car Porters, Chicago Division records (hereafter BSCP-CD), Chicago History Museum Research Center; Halena Wilson, letter to S.I. Hayakawa, April 28, 1944, 118–7, BSCP-CD.
33. "Peoples Coop Forum," March 1943, 118–6, BSCP-CD; S. Hayakawa and M. Hayakawa, 104–105, 135–138; and "Marge Hayakawa Becomes HPCS President," *Evergreen*, June 16, 1954, Folder 3, Box 43A, Hyde Park Co-op Records, Hyde Park Historical Society, University of Chicago Library.
34. S.I. Hayakawa, "Curriculum Vitae as of July 29, 1953," Folder 13, Box 429, SIH. Hayakawa stopped donating to the JACL after denouncing its support for the 1952 McCarran-Walter Act and the law's illiberal security provisions. See Robinson, 97–98; and Diane C. Fujino, "Cold War Activism and Japanese American Exceptionalism: Contested Solidarities and Decolonial Alternatives to Freedom," *Pacific Historical Review* 87, no. 2 (May 2018): 264–304.
35. "Hayakawa Accepts Committee Post," *Mill Valley Record*, August 14, 1958; and "Test case looms, three named to draft law on housing bias," *San Rafael Independent-Journal*, September 15, 1959.
36. "Freedom of Speech, Press, Under Attack Again by Senate Committee," January 1963; S.I. Hayakawa, "Friends of Free Radio in America," January 23, 1963; both in Folder 9, Box 429, SIH. "S.I. Hayakawa Heads Group on Fight for Freedom for Radio," *Nichi Bei Times*, January 11, 1963.
37. S.I. Hayakawa, untitled draft, n.d., Folder 7, Box 632, SIH; "Nisei Semanticist Calls for Revival of Militant Spirit to Gain Civil Rights," *Nichi Bei Times*, October 3, 1963; and "Communication: Interracial and International," *Fremont News Register*, October 3, 1963.
38. "Conference to hear speakers on civil rights," *Los Angeles Times*, February 27, 1964.
39. S.I. Hayakawa, "The F.S.M. Demonstrations," December 8, 1964, Folder 7, Box 31, Eric Hoffer Papers, HIA.
40. S.I. Hayakawa and Barry A. Goodfield, "Reflections on a Visit to Watts," *ETC: A Review of General Semantics* 23, no. 2 (September 1966): 295–326.
41. Indeed, the college administration already had approved a proposal in 1967 to create Black Studies, but disputes persisted over how and when the new academic unit would be created. See Biondi, *The Black Revolution on Campus*, 47–51.

42. William H. Orrick, *Shut It Down! A College in Crisis* (Washington, D.C.: U.S. Government Printing Office, 1969), 37–45; and Biondi, *The Black Revolution on Campus*, 57–58, 62.
43. The Movement Against Political Suspension was established in November 1967 to protest suspensions in conflicts around two student publications at SFSC, *Gater* and *Open Process*. Rojas argues that its creation was an outcome of the college's poorly defined and rarely enforced disciplinary code, which meant that "students felt that administrative actions were unjust because there were no rules about what constituted an appropriate limit on student behavior" ("Power Through Institutional Work," 1271). S.I. Hayakawa, untitled statement of events, December 1967, Folder 13, Box 630, SIH; United States Congress, House, Committee on Un-American Activities, *Subversive influences in riots, looting, and burning, Part 6 (San Francisco-Berkeley)*, 90th Congress, 2nd session (Washington, D.C.: Government Printing Office, 1969), 2054–2055.
44. Hayakawa, untitled statement of events.
45. S.I. Hayakawa, letter to John Summerskill, December 10, 1967, Folder 7, Box 630, SIH.
46. Untitled draft of Faculty Renaissance history and objectives, 1968; "Faculty Renaissance Movement," February 18, 1968; "Faculty Renaissance: Statement of Policy, Program, and Aims," October 1968; Carl Larson, letter to Faculty Renaissance group, January 1968; all in Folder 19, Box 626, SIH.
47. S.I. Hayakawa, "Remarks at SFSC Faculty Meeting, Friday, November 15, 1968," Folder 13, Box 630, SIH.
48. S.I. Hayakawa, "Public Statement by President S.I. Hayakawa," November 30, 1968, Folder 13, Box 630, SIH.
49. S.I. Hayakawa, "Operation Outreach: The Extension of Extension," October 1968, Folder 19, Box 626, SIH.
50. Hayakawa, "Public Statement."
51. Orrick, *Shut It Down!*, 58–59. Hayakawa would later explain that he meant "fun" in the sense that roller coasters evoke a feeling of "terror-relief," or a kind of "sublime" (Diehl (1972)).
52. Orrick, *Shut It Down!*, 60; and Biondi, *The Black Revolution on Campus*, 64–65. Notably, there are no files in the SIH papers that reflect his poor behavior.
53. Alan Nishio, "The Oriental as a 'Middleman Minority,'" *Gidra* 1, no. 2 (May 1969). It is possible that Nishio's ideas were influenced by sociologist Harry Kitano, with whom he may have worked at the UCLA Asian American Studies Center. My thanks to Calvin Cheung-Miaw for this insight. The first academic analysis of Asian Americans as a "racial middleman," published by sociologist Edna Bonacich and later in partnership with historian John Modell, argued that Chinese and Japanese Americans had acquired an intermediate economic status between the elite and the masses in part due to their immigration as "sojourners" who did not intend to stay and therefore preferred economic niches with highly liquid assets. Despised by both sides across the status gap and encountering political and economic exclusion, middleman minorities retreated into ethnic enclaves, drawing upon their ethnic solidarity to become economically mobile while avoiding political participation in order to balance their intermediate position. Edna Bonacich, "A Theory of Middleman Minorities," *American Sociological Review* 38, no. 5 (October 1973): 583–94; and Edna Bonacich and John Modell, *The Economic Basis of Ethnic Solidarity: Small Business in the Japanese American Community* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1980). Scholars have disputed Bonacich's characterization of Asian Americans as "sojourners" for promoting stereotypes of Asians as "unassimilable," and for attributing the sojourner choice to cultural factors and preferences while minimizing the impact of structural exclusion from the labor market. See Eugene F. Wong, "Asian American Middleman Minority Theory: The Framework of an Ethnic Myth," *Journal of Ethnic Studies* 3, no. 1 (1985): 51–86; and Pyong-Gap Min and Andrew Kolodny, "The Middleman Minority Characteristics of Korean Immigrants in the United States," *Korea Journal of Population and Development* 23, no. 2 (December 1994): 179–202. Recent discussions of Hayakawa as a "middleman" have not engaged the theoretical dimensions of the concept, but instead focus on his function as a buffer manipulated by white elites (Maeda, *Chains of Babylon*, 55–57).
54. Maeda, *Chains of Babylon*, 55–61.

55. Larry Kubota, "Necessary but not sufficient: Yellow Power!" *Gidra* 1, no. 1 (April 1969).
56. Nishio, "The Oriental as a 'Middleman Minority'."
57. Orrick, *Shut It Down!*, 100; and Laura Pulido, *Black, Brown, Yellow, and Left: Radical Activism in Southern California* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2006), 158.
58. Although the Mexican-American Student Alliance representative, Hari Dillon, was of South Asian descent and his grandfather had been a member of the anticolonial nationalist Ghadr Party, he did not specifically discuss Asian American student groups or communities. See Howard Finberg and Steve Toomajian, eds, *Crisis at SF State* (San Francisco: Insight Publications, 1969), 16–18; and Biondi, *The Black Revolution on Campus*, 46.
59. Various letters to S.I. Hayakawa, February to April 1969, Folder 1, Box 627, SIH.
60. John Dreyfuss, "Semantic Irony: Slogan Converts Hayakawa from Words to Action," *Los Angeles Times*, December 6, 1968. Hayakawa had developed friendships with musicians like Jackson and Duke Ellington through his time in Chicago.
61. Various political cartoons, Folder 8, Box 626, SIH.
62. California State Legislature, "Assembly Concurrent Resolution No. 2—Relative to Dr. S.I. Hayakawa and Trustees of the California State Colleges," January 7, 1969.
63. Fred Gillies, "Chair Hurlers Balk Hayakawa at CU, Violent Hour Precedes Talk by Educator," *Denver Post*, March 4, 1969.
64. S.I. Hayakawa, lecture sponsored by the W.F. Dyde Student Forum and Associated Students of the University of Colorado, March 3, 1969, Folder 2, Box 24, Edward J. Rozek papers, HIA.
65. "Hayakawa Hits 'New Hitlerism'"; Ken Pearce, "CU Antics 'Amuse' Hayakawa"; both in *Denver Post*, March 4, 1969.
66. "S.I. Hayakawa: He faced the student storm and won," *Alameda Times-Star*, December 5, 1972.
67. See [Figure 2](#).
68. "What They Say: Black Daily Shows Strong Support of Hayakawa Stand," *Hokubei Mainichi*, July 24, 1970; and Metz Lochard, letter to S.I. Hayakawa, November 22, 1976, Folder 7, Box 633, SIH.
69. "S.I. Rips *Gidra*"; "Editorial"; Laura Ho, "Red Guard Party"; all in *Gidra* 1, no. 2 (May 1969).
70. Nishio; Laura Ho, "Pigs, Pickets & a Banana," *Gidra* 1, no. 2 (May 1969).
71. Amy Tachiki, "Introduction," in *Roots: An Asian American Reader*, eds. Amy Tachiki, Eddie Wong, Franklin Odo, and Buck Wong (Los Angeles: UCLA Asian American Studies Center, 1971), 1–2.
72. Harry H.L. Kitano, *Japanese Americans: The Evolution of a Subculture* (Englewood Cliffs, NJ: Prentice-Hall, 1969), 104.
73. Hayakawa used the term "aristocratic" to describe his mother, Tora Isono, although it is difficult to tell exactly what the notion of representing "another class of people" may have meant to her. Isono was the daughter of a physician, perhaps imparting a sense of class superiority (S. Hayakawa and M. Hayakawa, 5; and S.I. Hayakawa, "Why I Want America to Win," n.d., Unpublished Papers, Box 411, SIH). The Japanese government also tried to ensure the respectability of its emigrants in response to the anti-Japanese movement, which may have also influenced Isono's attitudes toward other immigrants. See Ronald Takaki, *Strangers from a Different Shore* (Canada: Little Brown & Company, 1989), 45–48.
74. S.I. Hayakawa, "An Interview With Dr. S.I. Hayakawa," in *Roots: An Asian American Reader*, eds. Amy Tachiki, Eddie Wong, Franklin Odo, and Buck Wong (Los Angeles: UCLA Asian American Studies Center, 1971), 19–23.
75. "Negro Progress Held Back by Built-in Inferiority Complex, Hayakawa Says," *Hokubei Mainichi*, August 25, 1965; and Tom Wieder, "A Little Segregation Might Help the Negro, Says Dr. S.I. Hayakawa," *Monterey Peninsula Herald*, December 4, 1965.
76. For a critique of the historical division between separatism and integration, see Thomas J. Sugrue, *Sweet Land of Liberty: The Forgotten Struggle for Civil Rights in the North* (New York: Random House, 2008).
77. S.I. Hayakawa, lecture sponsored by Community Interest Committee of Nihonmachi (San Francisco), February 21, 1969, courtesy of Sharon Doi.
78. Hayakawa, "An Interview With Dr. S.I. Hayakawa," 21–22.

79. Early historians of the postwar conservative movement identified its origins in a populist “backlash” against the 1960s’ social movements; see, for example, Thomas Byrne Edsall and Mary D. Edsall, *Chain Reaction: The Impact of Race, Rights, and Taxes on American Politics* (New York: W.W. Norton & Company, 1991). Recent scholarship has identified deeper conservative networks and activism rooted in earlier decades, analyzing how new languages, networks, and politics of conservatism were developed by middle-class suburbanites across the Sunbelt states; see, for instance, Matthew D. Lassiter, *The Silent Majority: Suburban Politics in the Sunbelt South* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2006). For an overview of the historiography of modern conservatism, see Kim Phillips-Fein, “Conservatism: A State of the Field,” *Journal of American History* 98, no. 3 (December 2011): 723–43. For my analysis of Hayakawa’s location in the conservative movement, see endnote 12.
80. “Tell It like It Is: Conference on Democratic Party Reform and Reorganization,” April 11–13, 1969, Democratic Conference on Party Reform and Reorganization, Box 458, SIH; Katherine Bishop, “S. I. Hayakawa Dies at 85; and Scholar and Former Senator,” *New York Times*, February 27, 1992.
81. S.I. Hayakawa, letter to Richard Rodda, “Re: U.S. Senate Race Questionnaire,” May 12, 1976, Folder 2, Box 24, Edward J. Rozek papers (emphasis in the original).
82. Michael Roskin and Moon H. Jo, “Asian-American Political Participation,” in *Political Participation of Asian Americans: Problems and Strategies*, ed. Yung-Hwan Jo (Chicago: Pacific/Asian American Mental Health Research Center, 1980), 121.
83. Bayard Rustin, “From Protest to Politics: The Future of the Civil Rights Movement,” *Commentary* 2, no. 39 (February 1965). Rustin was harshly criticized for his essay; see, for instance, Staughton Lynd, “Coalition Politics or Nonviolent Revolution?” *Liberation* (June-July 1965). See also George Shulman, “Bayard Rustin: Between Democratic Theory and Black Political Thought,” in *African American Political Thought: A Collected History*, eds. Melvin L. Rogers and Jack Turner (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2020), 439–59.
84. Despite his infamous quip—“We should keep it. We stole it fair and square”—he ultimately voted in favor of returning the Canal. Ellen Hume, “Personally Popular: Hayakawa Still Struggles With Legislative Process,” *Los Angeles Times*, September 18, 1977; and Adam Clymer, *Drawing the Line at the Big Ditch: The Panama Canal Treaties and the Rise of the Right* (Lawrence, KS: University Press of Kansas, 2008).
85. Julian E. Zelizer, “Rethinking the history of American conservatism,” *Reviews in American History* 38, no. 2 (June 2010): 367–92.
86. Tateishi, *Redress*; Yang Murray, *Historical Memories of the Japanese American Internment and the Struggle for Redress*; Daniel Martinez HoSang, *Racial Propositions: Ballot Initiatives and the Making of Postwar California* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2010), 130–59; John Horton, *The Politics of Diversity: Immigration, Resistance, and Change in Monterey Park, California* (Philadelphia: Temple University Press, 1995); and Timothy P. Fong, *The First Suburban Chinatown: The Remaking of Monterey Park, California* (Philadelphia: Temple University Press, 1994).

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